



National shame: TV grab shows BJP MPs waving wads of notes in Parliament. They were allegedly bribed to vote for the UPA during the trust vote earlier this year.

India has been desperately trying to convince itself for the past few years that it is well on the way to becoming a major economic power, and has been turning its every major and even minor successes into a conclusive proof of it. This has generated a euphoria which blinds the country to its fundamental weaknesses that are bound to cause problems in the years to come.

One of the most important of these weaknesses relates to the crisis of character. A nation's character is evident in its commitment to basic moral norms, and its ability to form a clear sense of national purpose and to pursue it with determination and energy. India leaves much to be desired in this respect. Our crisis of character is reflected in our lack of collective purpose, weak social conscience, and the steady decline of values and norms in our civic and political life. Public office has increasingly come to be seen as private property to be used by the incumbent as he or she sees. Political life at the state level is dominated by an unholy triple alliance of politicians, businessmen and religious leaders. Many decisions of the Central Government show an unhealthy influence of corporate business houses. Some of our foreign policy decisions take inadequate account of our long-term material interest and display undue US influence. Successive governments have bought parliamentary votes and used the CBI to pursue politically convenient cases. Our police are a menace to ordinary citizens, and the visit to a police station is a virtual nightmare. We are increasingly reaching a point where we are no longer ashamed or even embarrassed at the flagrant violations of moral norms, and accept these as a normal part of life. No one is in the least worried that all this undermines the legitimacy of our democracy, and is likely to lead, over time, to disrespect for the law and ensuing violence.

Politicians are not the only ones involved in the relentless erosion of our moral life. How many journalists and columnists can claim not to be corrupted by their associations with politicians and businessmen? How many doctors,

lawyers and teachers can claim to be upright in their professional lives? And how many of our Bollywood stars and cricketers think twice before lowering the dignity of their profession and bringing it into disrepute by appearing in laughable and misleading advertisements? The financial corruption or the use of money to get unlawful things done—that rightly worries us greatly—is the result and a small part of the pervasive moral corruption. We can't tackle it unless we deal with its deeper roots.

Our problem is how to create a civic and political culture based on respect for moral norms and capable of nurturing public probity and placing carefully calibrated national interest at the centre of our concern. Mercifully we do not have to begin from the scratch. We laid the foundations of such a culture during our Independence struggle and in the two decades following Independence. Although we are fast dissipating that vital moral capital, we can draw inspiration and confidence from what we could do once and can do again if we put our collective minds to it.

Like all cultures, the kind of civic and political culture that I have in mind is the result of five important factors. First, we should cultivate a basic sense of values from an early age. The schools and the family obviously have a vital role to play, and they deserve encouragement and support. Public leaders can help by setting appropriate examples, and the media could highlight unknown heroes, who even in difficult circumstances live by basic values. They are the lotuses that add lustre to their environment, and deserve Padma awards more than businessmen and politicians.

Second, we need rigorously enforced laws that clearly lay down what is acceptable or unacceptable in public life, as with the anti-corruption laws of Lee Kwan Yew and rather tentatively in China, Botswana and South Africa. Only those should be allowed to fight elections who have a clean record. Political parties must be required to publish their accounts.

Rs 883cr

THE AMOUNT OF BRIBES
PAID BY POOR FAMILIES
IN 2007 TO ACCESS
11 PUBLIC SERVICES,
SAYS A TIJ-CMS
REPORT.